drawn to the Mallahs and Doms and spend many hours interacting with them.

The Boatmen of Varanasi

No journey to Varanasi is said to be complete without a boat ride on the Ganga, along its 7-km arc lined by about eighty ghats. As I have been advised, I begin at sunrise and take a rowboat from Assi Ghat. My bearded young boatman rows languidly, making a rhythmic sound with his oars and the river. His aging boat creaks in places. The city is quiet; a soft morning light suffuses the ghats and their temples, dormitories and former royal houses. Many visitors have waxed poetic about this ride. In mid-nineteenth century, M.A. Sherring, a British missionary and Indologist, spent a few years in the city and wrote, 'For picturesqueness and grandeur, no sight in the world can well surpass that of Benares as seen from the river Ganges.'[34] I feel some of that magic too until I reflect on the anaemic width of the summertime Ganga and its murkiness. I try not to think about a recent estimate that three-fourths of the Ganga pollution is from untreated municipal sewage from settlements along its banks.[35]

Street dogs abound on the ghats, playing out their rich social life and territorial games denied to their pet cousins. We pass Harishchandra Ghat, where a pyre burns even at this early hour. Most ghats seem tidier than they looked a decade ago. I see scores of devotees bathing, praying or offering water to the sun on Dashashwamedh Ghat, the most touristy ghat of the city. A chat with my boatman reveals that he'll vote saffron this time. We pass Manikarnika Ghat, smoky as ever, and I alight at the next stop, Scindia Ghat.